

SHAILESH RANA

HIGH RISE: Despite buffer stock in silos, foodgrain security is threatened



SHOWING A WAY OUT

Gujarat, the highest producer of oilseeds in the country, has enhanced its agricultural production by almost one and a half times in the last five-odd years, thanks to a multi-pronged strategy. Apart from successive good monsoons, the turnaround came because of efficient agro-management based on conservation of surface water, providing scientific information to farmers through the medium of Krishi Rath, and disbursement of a soil health card to every farmer. Tapping of surface water has been achieved by building 1.77 lakh farm ponds and 1 lakh check dams in public-private partnership, and deepening 5,000 village lakes, which has sent the water table soaring.

The soil health card policy—under which scientists attached to the four agro universities in the state go to every farm and test the soil quality—has played a major role. The card helps the farmer provide the right nutrients to the soil, thus saving on wasteful expenditure. Around 17 lakh farmers in Gujarat have already received such cards. No wonder productivity has gone up. *by Uday Mahurkar*



"Things appear gloomy, but we can change the situation in five years if we persist with our remedies."

P.K. MISHRA, UNION AGRICULTURE SECRETARY

per cent to 4 per cent by 2012. Says Agriculture Secretary P.K. Mishra, "Though things appears gloomy we can change the situation in the next five years if we go ahead with the remedies we have announced."

Experts say all these measures may not add up. Swaminathan feels there is "policy fatigue", with too much bureaucratisation of key agriculture missions. "We spend more time choosing our cricket coaches than selecting directors to these key missions," he points out. Alagh says old ideas take a long time to die in India and new ones cannot be built on "the corpses of old ones".

It is states like West Bengal, Bihar and Gujarat that are showing the way ahead. Gujarat has trebled agricultural productivity through excellent agro-management programmes that include conserving water, soil health care and making vital inputs available to farmers. In the rocky road ahead, states will have to take the initiative and play a key role in reviving Indian agriculture before it is too late.

with Subhash Mishra and Stephen David

20 m tonne rise in foodgrain demand expected in next four years.